

Practice Exercises on Cannot be True Questions

1.

Creating a database of all the plant species in the scientific record has proved to be no easy task. For centuries, botanists have been collecting and naming plants without realizing that many were in fact already named. And by using DNA analysis, botanists have shown that varieties of plants long thought to belong to the same species actually belong to different species.

Of the following claims, which one can most justifiably be rejected on the basis of the statements above?

- (A) Most of the duplicates and omissions among plant names in the scientific record have yet to be cleared up.
- (B) An accurate database of all the plant species in the scientific record can serve as an aid to botanists in their work.
- (C) Duplicates and omissions in the scientific record also occur in fields other than botany.
- (D) Botanists have no techniques for determining whether distinct plant species have been given distinct names.
- (E) A person who consults the scientific record looking under only one of a plant's names may miss available information about that plant.

2.

Good students learn more than what their parents and teachers compel them to learn. This requires that these students derive pleasure from the satisfaction of their curiosity, and one cannot experience such pleasure unless one is capable of concentrating on a topic so intently that one loses track of one's own identity.

If the statements above are true, each of the following could also be true EXCEPT:

- (A) Some people who are capable of becoming so absorbed in a topic that they lose track of their own identities are nevertheless incapable of deriving pleasure from the satisfaction of their curiosity.
- (B) Most good students do not derive pleasure from the satisfaction of their curiosity.
- (C) Many people who derive pleasure simply from the satisfaction of their curiosity are not good students.
- (D) Some people who are not good students derive pleasure from losing track of their own identities.
- (E) Most people who are capable of becoming so absorbed in a topic that they lose track of their own identities are not good students.

3.

For a ten-month period, the total monthly sales of new cars within the country of Calistan remained constant. During this period the monthly sales of new cars manufactured by Marvel Automobile Company doubled, and its share of the new car market within Calistan increased correspondingly. At the end of this period, emission standards were imposed on new cars sold within Calistan. During the three months following this imposition, Marvel Automobile Company's share of the Calistan market declined substantially even though its monthly sales within Calistan remained constant at the level reached in the last month of the ten-month period.

If the statements above are true, which one of the following CANNOT be true?

- (A) The total monthly sales within Calistan of new cars by companies other than Marvel Automobile Company decreased over the three months following the imposition of the emission standards.
- (B) Over the three months before the imposition of the emission standards, the combined market share of companies other than Marvel Automobile Company selling new cars in Calistan decreased.
- (C) If the emission standards had not been imposed, Marvel Automobile Company would have lost an even larger share of the number of new cars sold in Calistan than, in fact, it did.
- (D) A decrease in the total monthly sales of new cars within Calistan will occur if the emission standards remain in effect.
- (E) Since the imposition of the emission standards, Marvel Automobile Company's average profit on each new car sold within Calistan has increased.

4.

Two things are true of all immoral actions. First, if they are performed in public, they offend public sensibilities. Second, they are accompanied by feelings of guilt.

If all the statements above are true, then which one of the following must be false?

- (A) Some immoral actions that are not performed in public are not accompanied by feelings of guilt.
- (B) Immoral actions are wrong solely by virtue of being accompanied by feelings of guilt.
- (C) Some actions that offend public sensibilities if they are performed in public are not accompanied by feelings of guilt.
- (D) Some actions that are accompanied by feelings of guilt are not immoral, even if they frequently offend public sensibilities.
- (E) Every action performed in public that is accompanied by feelings of guilt is immoral.